Who really is a senior senior developer?

Senior Software Developer Programmers joke

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Do we type faster?
Do we write error-free code all the time?
Have we memorized all syntaxes and algorithms?
Do we know everything?

Probably not! That's a 10x dev job!

The myth of "years of blah blah" seniority in IT

The idea that seniority is only about the number of years in the field is misleading.
Just because someone has been coding for a decade doesn't mean they have been growing, learning, or adapting to new technologies.

Experience is valuable, but only if it is accompanied by continuous improvement, problem-solving skills, and the ability to make sound technical decisions.
There are people who have been doing the same thing for decades without even considering to learn something new.

Seniority isn't just about technical skills—it's also about leadership, communication, and understanding business needs. A great senior developer knows when to push back on unnecessary features, when to mentor junior engineers, and when to advocate for refactoring versus shipping quickly.

Value people who value learning, growth, and adaptability; and forget about measuring based on stupid things like "years of experience".

Time to ask yourself ...

Do we measure based on ...
Lines of code?
Number of commits?
Number of Pull Requests?
Number of fixed bugs?
Number of features?

If your answer is yes, then you'd probably hire based on "years of experience".

If you are looking for something to "show progress", such things can easily be tempting to be valued.
KPIs will be met. Something can be presented as "progress". High-level managers will be fooled, and mid-level managers will be happy!
If that's the case, "seniority" can also be measured by "years of experience" and metrics like that.

But real seniority is ...

But real seniority is about impact, decision-making, and mentorship. It's about knowing when less code is better, when not to reinvent the wheel, and how to guide a team towards better software, not just more software.

Instead of focusing on vanity metrics, ask deeper questions: Who is enabling the team to succeed? Who is reducing technical debt? Who is improving developer experience? These are the real signs of seniority.

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